



MONTHLY UPDATE

Burundi: monthly update, August – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-01 · 18 systems and instruments tracked

Developments summarised from sources published between the beginning of last month and today.

SUMMARY OF THE MONTH · GOVERNANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · INCLUSION

Summary of the month

Payments were the month's substance and electricity its limit. The national instant payment system had 17 of 78 licensed institutions live by 4 August, the central bank acceded to the pan-African payment and settlement system with four domestic banks authorised, and it told the regional governors it expects to join the East African cross-border payment network by December 2026. Against three rails opening, traders at Karusi report that electronic invoicing machines stop with every power cut.

The regulator says the same thing about connectivity. It conceded on 3 August that network quality is degraded and named six causes, four of them electricity, and later told a workshop that internet use in the country is low without publishing a figure. On the legislative side an access-to-information bill was listed on the National Assembly's order paper and consultation opened on a law regulating social-media influencers.

Governance

Legislation and regulation

An access-to-information bill is on the National Assembly's order paper for the session opened at the Kigobe Congress Palace on 3 August 2026. The first vice-president listed it among the bills the chamber will examine. Article 176 caps ordinary sessions at three months, putting the outer bound for passage in this sitting at roughly end-October 2026. No text, tabling number, sponsoring ministry or timetable was published and no copy is held — the announcement establishes only that the bill exists and is scheduled. Burundi has had no access-to-information statute on file to date.

The ministry opened consultations on the country's first dedicated framework for online publishing. A workshop on 26 August gathered influencers, content creators, legal experts and jurists for sector input before a bill regulating social-media influencers and content creators is finalised; no draft provisions are published, and whether the law would require registration, set disclosure rules for sponsored content, create an oversight body or set penalties is unestablished.

Regional collaboration

Two regional processes opened and neither has a text. A technical team agreed on 3 August, during the continental free-trade secretariat's mission to Bujumbura, to produce a country profile and an implementation roadmap, and consultation was held in Bujumbura on a memorandum for cross-border health-security cooperation with the regional authority. Neither carries a signature, a date or a funding line.

ICT Infrastructure

Connectivity

On 3 August the regulator ARCT [accepted that internet quality is degraded and named the causes](#): recurrent electricity cuts forcing base stations and data centres onto generators the operators struggle to fuel, unstable supply from the utility REGIDESO, bandwidth saturation in urban centres, ageing transmission equipment and simple absence of masts in parts of the country. It said it can apply the sanctions in operators' licence conditions, and named two remedies: a draft law enabling ICT infrastructure sharing and a PAFEN-financed mast-deployment programme. Lumitel and Econet Leo were contacted for that account and did not respond.

On the money side, the universal service fund's [revised FY2026/27 procurement plan carries BIF 11.40bn for dedicated IP transit](#) – 8 Mbit to public health facilities and 10 Mbit to schools – funded from the 1% levy on operator turnover rather than from the general budget.

Energy

Among the regulator's remedies for degraded service, named [on 3 August](#), is a planned study on powering mobile base stations.

DPI

Digital Identity and CRVS

Biometric civil registration is [operating in 13 pilot communes, decentralised to zone level and interoperable with health-facility birth and death records, with a national unique identifier planned on fingerprint and facial biometrics](#). The health-facility link is the part with numbers behind it: the interior ministry says it has been [piloted since 2023, institutionalised in 2024, and now runs in 123 health facilities where it has recorded more than 52,000 births](#). No coverage denominator is given for either figure.

It is being built onto a base that already reaches most children: [84% of under-fives are registered at birth and 66% hold a birth certificate](#), cited by government on Africa Civil Registration Day. The gap between the two figures is the one the platform has to close.

Digital Payments and Fintech

Three payment rails moved. The national instant payment system, launched publicly in April, [had 17 of 78 licensed institutions live by 4 August, five commercial banks and ten microfinance institutions among them](#). The central bank acceded to the pan-African payment and settlement system, with four domestic banks authorised to participate, and [told the regional governors it expects to join the East African cross-border payment network by December 2026](#).

At the counter, none of that reaches the constraint. Traders at Karusi [report that electronic invoicing machines stop with every power cut](#), which is the same limit the regulator names for network quality.

Sectoral management information systems

The one new management system in the window sits outside the state's own stack. A [digital tool for tracking the institutional performance of Burundi's technical and vocational training centres in real time was validated on 7 August](#), built by CREOP-Jeunes under the EU-backed Umwuga Akazi project. No deployment date, centre count or custodian ministry is stated, so what the tool will be attached to is not yet on the record.

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The revenue authority's online tax platform, live since January, [became the exclusive channel for new taxpayer registrations from 4 August](#). Making a channel exclusive is the point at which a platform's availability becomes a condition of registering at all, and no fallback, uptime figure or exemption is stated.

Inclusion

Access to services

A rural community digital hub [opened at Shombo](#). It is a single site reported by its own organisers; no programme, national count, funding line or usage figure stands behind it.

Digital divides

The telecommunications regulator told a workshop that very few Burundians use the internet. It characterised the level without publishing a figure, so the finding the base can carry is the regulator's own [statement that use is low](#), not a percentage.

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